

Non-negotiables, Not rules, commitment to a way of life. Hieromartyr Lucian of Antioch teaches us how to get ready!

A letter from Priest Seraphim. 20th Sunday after Pentecost. Oct 17/30, 2022

http://www.orthodox.net/letters/letter_2022-10-30+20th-sun+rules-non-negotiables-hieromartyr-lucian.docx
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I can see that it's five weeks since I last wrote a letter. My aim is to write a letter every single week. I like to kind of do a little dump of my heart (a poetic way to put it - not!) to anybody that will listen. I just got a letter from someone asking to check to see if she was still on the mailing list because there haven't been letters for so long. I don't feel good that I haven't sent a letter for five weeks but I do feel good that somebody noticed. A lot of times a priest feels like he spits in the ocean. But that's just a passion. If we do the smallest thing, including giving a cup of water to a little one God, remembers this. Sometimes the smallest thing we do turns a person toward the light.

Non-negotiables.

I have so many things that I could write, but I don't end up writing them sometimes because the days are just so full. I have things every day that I make sure that I do, and there are also things that I must do, especially because of my pastoral responsibilities.

I hope that you have things that you absolutely think are nonnegotiable as to your daily activities. For me, those things include my morning rule, which usually includes the Psalter and the Akathist to the Theotokos "The Inexhaustible Cup," and my commemorations. And of course, there are prostrations with everything. I also want to say the Jesus prayer at least 300 times in the morning, and read the lives of the saints. Full disclosure - there are days when I have been up so late and have to get up so early that my daily rule only includes some introductory prayers and my commemorations and the Akathist. Or sometimes, not the Akathist, and I have to

figure out some way to say it during the day or the evening because it's a commitment that I've made.

Not rules, commitment to a way of life.

You should make commitments, especially concerning your prayer. We have this term: "prayer rule", and in some ways, it's an unfortunate term because the word "rule" brings to mind legal requirements in some people's minds. There is *no legal requirement regarding your prayer*. There's also no *legal requirement for you to eat and drink every day*. But without eating and drinking AND prayer, you will die. The prayer rule perhaps should be renamed to "prayer way of life" or something else. If we don't pray and pursue an inner life, we are absolutely nothing. It doesn't matter what other work we do and even if we do good work. If we don't pursue an inner life, we are basically dead.

Perhaps it's scary to some people, but it doesn't scare me. The reason is that when you pursue an inner life, even if you're bad at it like I am, a person feels the mercy of God, and since God is our Father, He will never abandon us. A good father never abandons his children no matter how bad they become. However, a good father will discipline his children and guide them.

I have learned that pursuing an inner life in prayer is not so much about being good at it as trying really hard, and prioritizing. I'm not good at anything but I'm getting better. Our prayers and services tell us that. They remind us that we were not good at anything without God, but God will help us, and that what is impossible with men is actually quite easy for God. But we must do our part. We must prioritize our prayer life and not content ourselves with skimpy little prayers

and rarely praying for others and having a dusty Bible and a dusty Psalter.

I told you above that there are days I don't read the Psalter but my Psalter is definitely not dusty! And, the day that I don't read it, is because God values obedience above prayer. But He doesn't value obedience in order to shirk prayer: we must know the difference! There are just times when there are too much for me to do, too many people to see, too many places to go, services are very early, etc., that I cannot get the Psalter read that day. But if I'm lucky, (and I already told you I am not good, so I suppose some days "it's better to be lucky than good"), I might read twice as much, as usual, the next day.

So, if you don't have a prayer rule, that's okay, create a prayer way of life. Prioritize prayer when you're at your best, whether it's the morning or the evening, or both. Absolutely, positively, pray for people that are around you and in your life, the ones you like and those you don't like. Make sure that you do prostrations or if you can't do prostrations, bows. Read the Psalter. I know that it can be difficult sometimes. But the more you read it, the more it gets into your bones and becomes beautiful. And the Psalter contains every human condition and the response that we should have to it.

A positive thing about a prayer way of life is that if you don't do a very good job in the morning, you can do a better job in the afternoon, and if you have a bad day, you can have a better day tomorrow. It's about begging God to help you, and He will!

A little bit of news.

We closed out our old house Friday. I think we've been working almost every day with the old house or the new house for three months. Now, finally I am behind *only* on the new house! And I can now get back to a few things like working out in the garage and doing videos and writing more letters.

Normally I want to write a letter that's totally original and appears nowhere else but I did a video on St. Lucian the Hieromartyr of Antioch Friday. And I even transcribed and edited it. I will include it for you here, even though you might get another email. The reason why is because all the time, at least with my family, and sometimes others who are on the mailing list, I say "did you see this or that," and they say "no." Sometimes I think the easiest way to keep a secret is to announce it!

Catechesis is learning to be like Christ

I've been thinking a lot about catechesis. All catechesis is learning how to be like Christ. All the other details are only important insofar as they give us a vocabulary to learn to be like Christ. And my small sermon about St. Lucian is an example of what we should be. Yes, please, read the Psalter, read the Scriptures and have a prayer rule and fast correctly and come to church and do prostrations! Of course, we must do all these things. We should understand the Symbol of Faith, and we should understand the services. We have to know things in order to be comfortable with them, however, the thing that we must know the most is to become like Christ, and Saint Lucian was so much like Christ that the people were edified just by looking at his face.

Hieromartyr Lucian of Antioch teaches us how to get ready! Oct 15

Text: http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/saints-10-15_2022+hieromartyr-lucian.docx

Text: http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/saints-10-15_2022+hieromartyr-lucian.pdf

YouTube: <https://youtu.be/2eOEOFYQuFY>

Audio: http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/saints-10-15_2022+hieromartyr-lucian.mp3

Description: Hieromartyr Lucian of Antioch was a martyr at the beginning of the fourth century. Two remarkable things about his life are examples for us, and we are required to be **visible** vessels of the Holy Spirit, just as he was and is. We have a long way to go. A unique of his life is that, when in prison awaiting torture and execution, he celebrated Divine liturgy on his chest. We explain why these things matter for anybody, whether they be a man woman or child, priest, or lay. His martyrdom and indeed his whole ministry was only possible because he led an inner life in Christ. We must strive for this life or else we may be obliterated by the upcoming troubles. Remember, most people apostasized! Don't let this scare you beyond measure! We just need to work harder, don't we? ALL of us catechumens (all of us!) must learn from this. Our learning is **only** to become like Christ. This is done **only** by learning to acquire an inner life! (The text is a modified transcription of the video/Audio)

In the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit, amen. On October 15th, we celebrate the holy Hieromartyr Lucian who was martyred just at the beginning of the fourth century. There are many edifying things about his life, but I want to cut to the two most important things that really shake me. That's why I read the lives of the saints; because they shake me up, and I want to follow them, not exactly as far as the circumstances of their life, but according to their heart.

Lucian was in an area where the emperor was persecuting Christians, and he was helping many people to be strong in the faith. There were a lot of people that were apostatizing. Remember: for everybody in the book of the synaxarion or the Menologion, there are hundred people who apostatize! Most people are going to apostatize, because that way to Hell is broad and because they're afraid. Perhaps you and I would be afraid. Let's not be so quick to judge, but let's do something so that we'll be ready.

Even the look of his face, which was shining with the Holy Spirit, would cause people become strong and overcome their fear. And that really got me. I'm a priest, I talk to people about things all the time, and I tried to live them, and to some extent, I live them. I certainly loved them more than some of the people I'm teaching. But could I say that my appearance is that of a Holy Spirit? I am such a vessel because I am a Christian, but do I look like one? Do I act like one? Does the mere vision of my face cause people to say "I feel better, I can believe now?" I don't think so, but it should be that way. We have a long way to go as Christians, because we're not like Saint Lucian. Maybe some of us are, but I'm not like him, unfortunately, We should emulate him. We should be having an inner life so that when people look at

us, they see Christ. I can talk about Christ, I can teach about Christ, I can pray to Christ. I can teach other people about Christ in some way, but can I really be Christ for people? Well, I think by the grace of God sometimes that happens, but not because of my virtues, because God says, "well, I need this donkey to do something," and the donkey does something.

This is the first thing about Saint Lucian's life that I think is pretty amazing, that he enlightened people merely by his presence, and by the peace of God, which was in his heart, and also by his fearlessness. He was unafraid of torture, and ministered to the Christian's welfare, and of course, he eventually got found out and was arrested and thrown in a dungeon.

The time for Theophany came, and he wanted to celebrate liturgy. Some bread and wine had been smuggled into the prison. In those days this was easier to do. People pretty much didn't eat or have any care whatsoever unless their loved ones visited them in prison to give them food, medical assistance and clothing. Nowadays, you have to have all kinds of permission to go to prison and, not so long, you had to wear a mask and, in some parts, you had to prove that you were vaccinated. I didn't have a chance to get in there. But in the old ancient prisons, people came to the ancient prisons all the time to attend to their loved ones. They smuggled in some wine and some bread, and he served the liturgy.

He didn't have an altar; he didn't have an antimins (the antimins is a cloth which has the relics of one or more martyrs sewn into it. It is required that we serve liturgy on antimins). What did he do? He served the liturgy on his chest. That's pretty amazing, isn't it? That's, shall we say, thinking outside of the box.

May we have that kind of faith that Saint Lucian had. What do his life and extraordinary exploits have to do with you and me? Perhaps you're a woman or a child, not a priest. What does this have to do with you? There's currently no open persecution because of paganism, not yet. You're not in prison, or if you are in prison, it's a different kind of prison. And if you want to have the liturgy celebrated, you go to church. What is this have to do with you?

It has everything to do with you! We must live the inner life, and we should feel rebuked by a person like Lucian, that we don't live the inner life. May God forgive us for this. That's why we must do our prostrations. That's why we must love our enemy. That's why we must come to church more often. That's why we need to commune and confess more often. We need to do all those things because we should have the light of Christ, showing in our faces. People should look at our faces and say, "Something about them is different."

Regarding Saint Lucian celebrating the liturgy on his chest, our tradition is to celebrate the liturgies on an antimins, which always has the relics of a martyr. He knew he was going to be martyred, so he kind of did it "by anticipation."

And I'll tell you, if there was a woman in the prison waiting to be martyred, I'd serve the liturgy on her chest, absolutely. It's not a man-woman

thing. Obviously only a man can be a priest, but God recognizes grace in anyone.

Read the life of Saint Mary of Egypt, and you can see that. Saint Zosimas (a priest) wanted to take a blessing from Mary of Egypt, and eventually out of obedience, he prevailed on her to give him her blessing as a laywoman.

May God help us to have that kind of faith, that St Lucian had, that we are not afraid of persecution. It happening, it's coming. It's going to increase in a slow way, in (to borrow a political phrase), a "kindler gentler way," but there is not going to be anything kinder gentle about it, it's just not going to be openly bloody until later.

Do we have the courage? Do we have the courage? We won't have the courage unless we live an inner life. Let's you and I decide that we're going to lead an inner life. Pray a little bit more; pray a lot more, and fast correctly, live the Christian life and struggle!

And ask great martyrs like Lucian to intercede for our poor selves, because we're weak and perhaps we would fall. perhaps will fall even with a little pebble in our path, much less. Some gigantic persecution. May God help us. We need to live the inner life - right now, because times are not getting better. They're getting worse, but "God is with us. Understand all ye nations and be vanquished. For God is with us." God bless you.

Recent Stuff:

[Children are a mirror in which we see ourselves.](#) 2022-10-22

When we see children's behavior, we sometimes see an exaggerated view of ourselves. They have much to teach us. A little story about 2 children and winning and losing illustrates this important source of learning about ourselves.

Video: <https://youtu.be/F4QuW358h68>

Audio: http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/misc_2022+children-are-a-mirror-in-which-we-see-ourselves.mp3

Timestamps:

[0:00 – 1:59](#) A "parable" about 2 children, "rock, paper, scissors", and winning and losing.

[3:33 – 4:55](#) Children are a mirror in which we see ourselves.

[4:55 – 6:32](#) The proper response when we see a person sinning, especially a "big sin."

[Exhortation to newly made Catechumens.](#) 2022-10-16 Len 12:28

An overview of what a catechumen *should be doing* and *trying to obtain* during their catechumenate.

YouTube: http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/catechesis_2022-11-16+exhortaion-to-newly-made-catechumens.mp3

Audio: <https://youtu.be/4VcrOZePBC0>

Timestamp Links:

[0:02 - 0:34](#) An informal and totally true description of the priesthood.

[0:34 - 1:25](#) Requirements and privileges of the catechumenate.

[1:25 - 2:41](#) Regarding symbolism vs reality in our services, and particularly the prayers at the making of a catechumen. Examples: a priest blowing on a person or blessing a person with the sign of the cross, and the exorcism prayers.

[2:41 - 3:48](#) A catechumen must be fasting in obedience to the mind of the church. And about personal and corporate obedience in things such as fasting, attending church services, etc.

[3:48](#) Orthodox Christianity is completely different from the experience of a person from any Christian belief. And regarding the state of mind of deep humility and recognizing our darkness, and at the same time, experiencing God's light.

[4:46 - 5:10](#) What is the point of baptism? To become good, not just be forgiven.

[5:10 - 6:46](#) You must learn to live rigorously.

[5:28 - 6:31](#) You must have a prayer rule. Is it a sin to miss your prayer rule? That is not the right question.

[6:31 - 6:46](#) The Christian life IS intense, and requires discipline, but it is not "rule based."

[6:46 - 7:16](#) A Catechumen should not read religious text other than Orthodox texts, or worship in non-Orthodox churches.

[7:16 - 11:00](#) Your struggle is to overcome the individualism that infects Western culture, and acquire the mind of the church.

[8:53 - 9:19](#) Why do we pray for the dead?

[9:20 - 10:02](#) What about all those prayers to Mary, the Theotokos?

[12:11 - 12:28](#) Do witnesses of a baptism or the prayers at the making of a catechumen have any obligations?